Gandhi and others were highly publicly critical of the Rowlatt Act. They scheduled rallies and demonstrations during which protesters prayed, fasted, and protested peacefully. In some cities, however, the demonstrations turned to rioting, which led Gandhi to order them stopped. He could not support widespread protests unless they were strictly violence free. When the act came into effect, two leading members of the National Congress—Dr. Satya Pal and Dr. Saifuddin Kitchlew—were arrested. To prevent further protests, the army was sent into Punjab during the same week as many Sikhs traveled there to celebrate Baisakhi Day. On April 13th, peaceful protests in Amritsar against the deportation of more political leaders sparked a response from the army and fighting soon got out of control. More than hundreds of people were murdered and over a thousand were injured at the hands of the army. Thereafter, it was called the Massacre of Amritsar.

With the army operating under the leadership of the British Crown, the Baisakhi Day killings convinced most Indians that Great Britain was indeed the enemy. Angry that his compatriots could not keep their protesting violence free and avoid the wrath of the British guards, Gandhi began a fast to try to inspire his countrymen and women to consider their actions more carefully. Two years later, Mohandas himself was put in charge of the Indian National Congress, and there was no question in which direction he wanted to take his political party.

Muslim outreach went well when Gandhi expressed his support of the Turkish Caliphate, but it disappeared just as quickly when that Turkish regime collapsed in 1922. Even so, he had a great deal of the country´s popular support. People called him “Mahatma” and followed his example of non-cooperation with British legislation. They boycotted British goods and tried to only buy Indian products. Gandhi himself wore only plain garments spun from Indian wool, denouncing expensive clothing items that not all of his fellow Indians could afford to wear.

Gandhi was arrested on March 10th, 1922, for sedition. Sentenced to six years in prison, he only served two before being released for medical reasons. Following an appendicitis operation, the political leader was released and quickly returned to his work.